

One Step Forward, Two Steps Back

How many of us own the latest 3G cell phone, 64 MB handheld or a DVD-Writer? Not too many, but we sure wish that we did.

These cool toys have tremendous drool value that's built up by all the marketing hype created around them. And companies need to sustain this hype in order to boast that they've got the biggest, fastest, or most powerful technology product in the world. Plus they get to build a feel good factor with their shareholders, stock analysts and the general consumer who ends up associating any product or technology from that company as the best available.

Why are we letting a bunch of marketers dictate what we need?

We need to realise that the increased utility offered by most of these technological innovations is purely incremental—there's no 'this-will-change-my-life' experience associated with them. Actually, the benefits of most 'cool' technologies are negated when you realise that instead of speeding up efficiency, or allowing us to accomplish the same amount of work in less time, we are often faced with expectations that more must be done in the same time.

Also the gee-whiz appeal with owning the largest hard disk, the fastest CPU and the most powerful video card is short-lived—there's always a better, faster, and more affordable technology around the corner. In the end what's important is whether your new printer is capable of printing more than 500 print-outs with a single ink cartridge and not whether it prints at 1200 or 2400 dpi since you won't notice a perceptible difference in the first place. It doesn't matter whether your killer 2 GHz notebook is three times faster than your desktop PC, if it won't let you watch an entire DVD movie during those boring flights without requiring a battery recharge in the middle.

We mistakenly concentrate only on unnecessary 'tangible' aspects of technology—how fast or powerful it is—whereas we need to look at whether new technological innovations fulfil their basic promise of greater convenience, simplicity and efficiency.

What we really need are products and technologies that will simplify and enrich our lives, allowing us to do things we actually care about—more free time for family, personal goals and recreation.

And the only way this will happen is if we look beyond the hype and start demanding the so-called innovators to drive innovations that really matter to their customers—that's you and me.



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